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STATIONS OF THE CROSS: A TWENTY-FIRST CENTURY CHRISTIAN REFLECTION

Written by: Festus Cobena Ainoo

Lent, as a liturgical season, may give enough time for us to reflect on the many truths of our religion. There are many topics we might think about as we try to fill our Lenten journey with prayer, fasting, and almsgiving. One of the first thoughts that comes to mind is man's need for God's grace: we can only achieve our ultimate goal of everlasting life with the aid of God's grace and Christ's death and resurrection. The cross is a symbol of this reality because it is the tool through which Christ gave Himself up for mankind's sins, transforming death into eternal life.

Praying the Stations of the Cross may assist us in reflecting on this aspect of our faith. This collection of prayers recounts the events of Christ's suffering and death, beginning with His condemnation by Pontius Pilate and concluding with His burial. The Stations of the Cross are a great method for us to reflect on the specific ways in which Christ handed up His life for us, and we may be motivated to think more about how we may model our own lives after Christ's. Let us pause for a moment to evaluate each of these occurrences and what we may learn from each station.

The First Station: *Pilate Condemns Jesus to Die*



Condemnation is a notion that many modern Christians are familiar with. Although we may not face widespread censure, it might be difficult to remain faithful in Christian beliefs

when it appears that many individuals we encounter belittle or criticize what we believe. Remember this beatitude: "Blessed are those who are persecuted for righteousness' sake, because theirs is the kingdom of heaven." Let us comprehend that it is critical to maintain our faith even in the face of judgment, and that our recompense is not temporal but everlasting.

The Second Station: *Jesus Accepts His Cross*



This seemingly basic station is one of the most significant for teaching us how to live our Christian lives in everyday situations. There are numerous times in our life when we are confronted with hardship, and it is frequently difficult to handle. However, every adversity, no matter how big or small, gives us the chance to die to ourselves, as Jesus did, and accept our suffering cheerfully.

The Third Station: *Jesus Falls for the First Time*



The crucifixion may have been light to Jesus, but the weight of humanity's sins made it impossible to carry, according to the prayer for this station. This invites us to consider what we do when we love someone. When we love someone, we want to alleviate their pain in whatever manner we can or prevent them from hurting in the first place. In loving Jesus and considering the weight of our sins causing Him to suffer, let us vow more firmly to live our life as sin-free as possible, and thus grow closer to Jesus in our attempts to love Him well and relieve His load.

The Fourth Station: *Jesus Meets His Mother, Mary*



We might explore what it genuinely means to pronounce fiat, or "Thy will be done," if we consider what Mary must have been feeling at the time. Mary began her journey as Jesus' mother by telling the angel Gabriel, "Thy will be done." She continued to lay herself aside as she repeated that edict every day of her life, even as she observed her beloved Son's great pain. This reminds us that our pledges to live as Catholics must be renewed every instant of our life, especially when it is incredibly difficult to do so.

The Fifth Station: ***Simon of Cyrene Helps Carry the Cross***



While meditating on this station, we have the chance to consider how we tolerate pain in our lives. The Romans forced Simon of Cyrene to bore the cross rather than inviting him to do so. The attitude with which he accepted this responsibility is unknown from the biblical scriptures. Did he bear Jesus' cross without grumbling? Or did he do it reluctantly and grudgingly? Every day, we are called to share in Jesus' agony. Let us, like Simon, accept it, but let us take it as happily and graciously as we can.

The Sixth Station: ***Veronica Wipes the Face of Jesus***



"What you have done to the least of my brethren, you have done to Me," Veronica's simple yet tremendously loving deed of wiping Jesus' face invites us to contemplate this phrase: "What you have done to the least of my brethren, you have done to Me." Every connection we have with our fellow men and women provides us with the chance to recognize Christ in others. Let us constantly love people we encounter as if we were loving Christ Himself, and try extra hard to see Christ in those who may be overlooked by many.

The Seventh Station: ***Jesus Falls for the Second Time***



While meditating on this seventh level, we might consider the interaction between our body and soul. Many times, because to our fallen nature, our bodies and souls do not connect, and we feel compelled to do something harmful to our souls. We understand how vital it is for us to be guided by our spirits rather than our bodies. Although Jesus must have struggled to get back up to bear the cross after this fall, His soul led the way and directed His body to continue. May we, too, draw courage from the depths of our hearts to always do what is right and allow our souls to control our earthly bodies.

The Eighth Station: *Jesus Meets the Women of Jerusalem*



This station provides us with another opportunity to consider the root reason of Jesus' grief. The ladies of Jerusalem sobbed as they witnessed Him physically suffer in His passion. "Weep for your sins and the sins of your children, for they are the cause of My suffering," Jesus says to the ladies. Let us remember, as we remember the events of His passion, that it was the weight of our sins that led Him to suffer, and seek to live pure lives now.

The Ninth Station: ***Jesus Falls for the Third Time***



Thinking about Jesus' third fall gives us a chance to be thankful. We are always appreciative in our life to individuals who do things for us even if it causes them additional discomfort or difficulties. Because Jesus' third fall was likely His most terrible, focusing on this station leads us to be grateful for the enormity of Jesus' sacrifice for our sins.

The Tenth Station: ***Jesus is Stripped of His Garments***



This station makes us consider the virtue of humility. It was essential for Jesus to become man in order to give people the gift of salvation and eternal life. To humble Himself and become one of us required the greatest act of humility on His behalf. This station might be seen as Jesus' willingness to lower Himself to the level of our humanity so that we can all be saved.

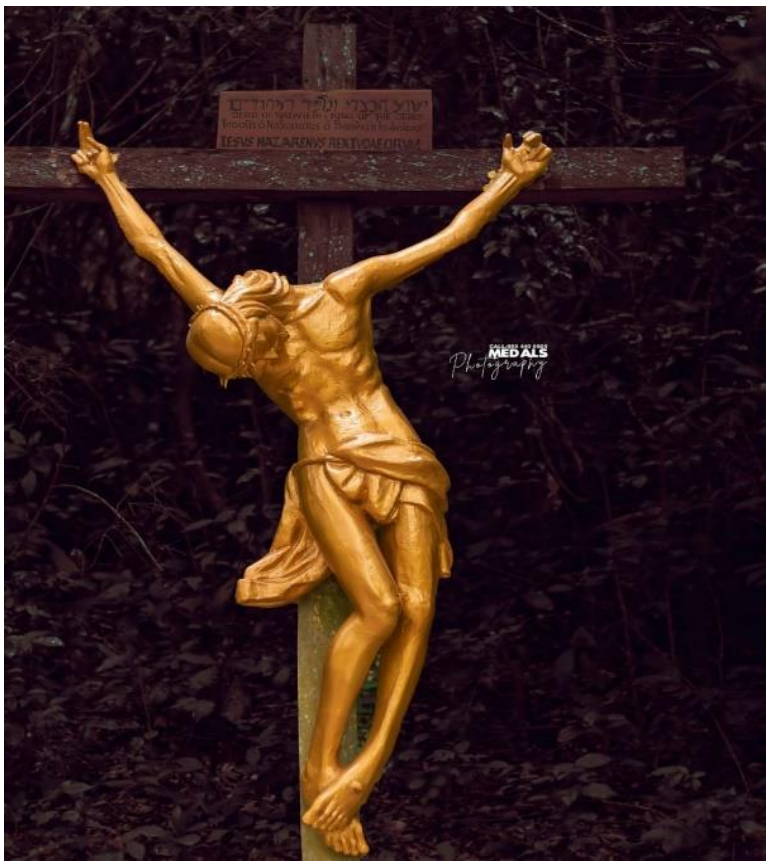
The Eleventh Station: *Jesus is Nailed to the Cross*



Thinking about Jesus' unwavering suffering reminds us of what it means to be patient and willing in the face of adversity. Despite the excruciating suffering He must have been feeling at the moment, He said nothing. Let us, like Jesus, offer up our suffering silently and without complaint as we confront whatever difficulties we must face in our life.

Reflection: Reading Psalm 22:1 “My God, my God, why have you abandoned me?” gives us greater insight to how Jesus felt in His final moments. We feel the pain and grief of an innocent who is following God’s will and see Scripture predicting the death of Jesus on the cross.

The Twelfth Station: ***Jesus Dies on the Cross***



A minute of quiet is observed here during the Stations of the Cross as we remember Christ laying down His life for us. His death was a watershed moment in Christian history: in dying, He abolished death's hold over us and used death itself as part of His salvific purpose. Let us never forget His sacrifice as we strive for salvation in our Christian life.

Keep in mind that it was never the nails that kept Jesus on the cross. He is the divine Son of God. He could have sent legions of angels in an instant to save Him from this horrible agony! Love was what kept Jesus on the cross. It was His intentional, ongoing decision to remain on that cross to the end. It was His desire to show mercy to us, sinners, that kept Him on the cross.

When we are suffering in this world, we usually want rapid alleviation. We want the quickest route through. But what can we learn from the cross about suffering? So, where am I currently suffering in my life? Who truly has the upper hand? And how does the Father invite me to suffer in the same way that Jesus did?

The Thirteenth Station: ***Jesus is Taken Down from the Cross***



This station evokes the virtue of endurance. Jesus stayed on the crucifixion until He completely surrendered His spirit, at which point He was carried down and placed to rest for a brief while on His adored mother. "For he who perseveres until the end shall be saved," we repeat as we pray for this station. As we concentrate our gaze on heaven, may we constantly persist and do what is right in our earthly lives.

Reflection: It is over. Jesus' lifeless corpse was taken down from the Cross and placed in his mother's arms. What a contradiction she experienced. Mary had held Jesus when he was an infant, and now she holds her dead Son's body — all so that we might gain eternal life.

It is never easy to say goodbye to those we love. Illness and death are unavoidable. While we are aware of this truth, our emotions never seem to be prepared for the anguish brought by death and the absence of a loved one. But, according to the Way of the Cross, we know that death does not have the ultimate say. Thank you, Jesus, for the suffering you endured so that we could one day be joined with you, Mary, our Mother, and all those who have gone before us.

The Fourteenth Station: ***Jesus is Placed in the Tomb***



Consider the theological virtue of hope in this context. Jesus' stay in the tomb is a period of stillness during which we expect for His resurrection. May we never be unnecessarily burdened by earthly sufferings, but always face our trials and tribulations with pleasure and the assurance of everlasting rest in paradise.

Reading: Amen, amen, I say to you, unless a grain of wheat falls to the ground and dies, it remains just a grain of wheat; but if it dies, it produces much fruit. Whoever loves his life loses it, and whoever hates his life in this world will preserve it for eternal life. Whoever serves me must follow me, and where I am, there also will my servant be. The Father will honor whoever serves me. - John 12:24-26

Reflection: While the 14th station brings the Way of the Cross to a close, we know that it is not the conclusion of the tale. God destroys the power of death via Jesus. Love always triumphs. To claim the resurrection, however, we must also claim the Cross.

In essence, the stations arose from imitations of Jerusalem's Via Dolorosa, a classic processional route symbolizing the real road Jesus took to Mount Calvary. The stations' purpose is to assist the Christian faithful in making a spiritual trip through contemplation on Christ's Passion.

ANNOTATIONS FROM A VISIT TO FRANCISCAN VALLEY OF PRAYER AND SILENCE – SALTPOND, CENTRAL REGION

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